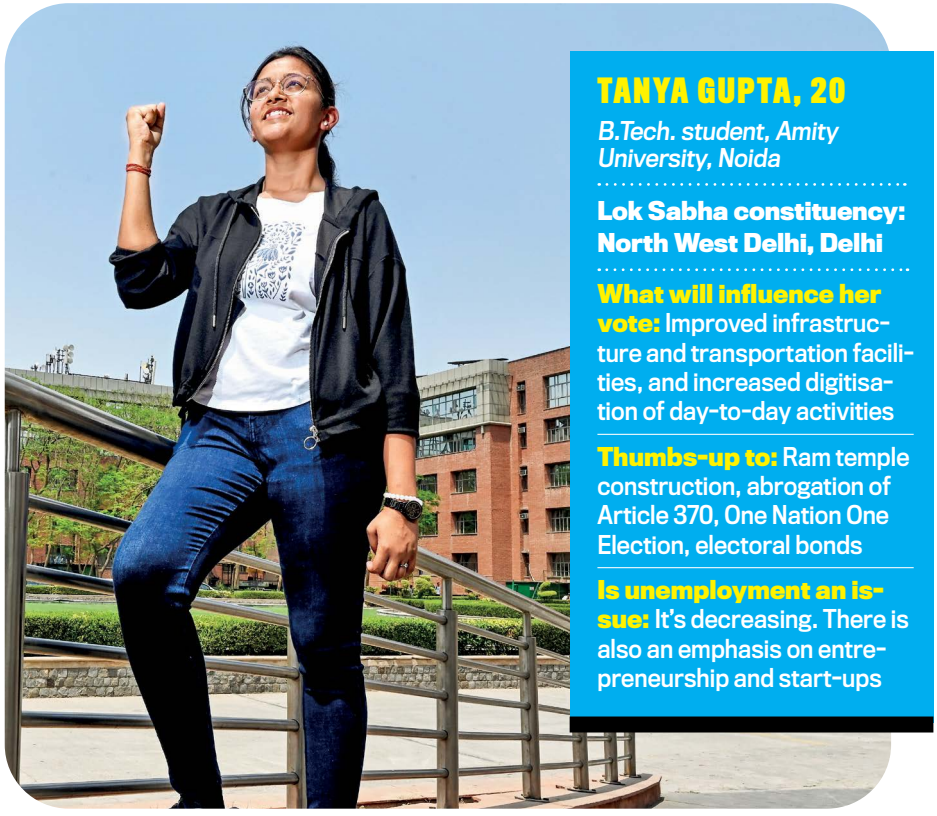
POLICY OVER POPULISM

For a first-time voter sans any political affiliation, 20-year-old Computer Science Engineering student Tanya Gupta is forthright in her political views. Daughter of a businessman father and a working mother, Gupta calls voting her fundamental right to participate in the country's decision-making process. "In my opinion, every single vote matters," she says. Improved infrastructure and transportation facilities as well as the increased digitisation of day-to-day activities are some of the issues that will influence her voting choice. "Being a day scholar myself, I have to travel about four hours every day and the ease in booking and tracking my journey has taken a burden off my shoulders," says Gupta, who has deep admiration for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and minister of external affairs S. Jaishankar. She believes India's image in the world has improved considerably. Between PM Modi and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, she chooses the former as she thinks the PM has a futuristic vision.

"For me, the issues raised by a party and beliefs of the leaders hold importance while making my voting choice"

Gupta feels religion is such a sensitive topic that it shouldn't be taken lightly. She says for the majority of the country, the Ram temple's inauguration was a deeply emotional event. Regarding freebies offered during polls, she says if they are just a means to secure vote and political parties aren't concerned about the people after their win, then it is nothing short of a scam. She, however, appreciates the Congress's promise of right to apprenticeship and employment, but cautions against throwing open jobs haphazardly to fulfil a poll promise. "It will lead to unfair distribution of career opportunities, which can harm potential applicants," she says, embodying the conscientious perspective of a new voter. ■ **-Shelly Anand**



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

TANYA GUPTA, 20

B.Tech. student, Amity University, Noida

Lok Sabha constituency: North West Delhi, Delhi

What will influence her vote: Improved infrastructure and transportation facilities, and increased digitisation of day-to-day activities

Thumbs-up to: Ram temple construction, abrogation of Article 370, One Nation One Election, electoral bonds

Is unemployment an issue: It's decreasing. There is also an emphasis on entrepreneurship and start-ups



VARSHA, 28

(She/they) Queer and Feminist Activist

Lok Sabha constituency: North East Delhi, Delhi

What will influence their vote: The attitude towards LGBTQ+ rights

"For queer and transpersons, the natal family becomes a site of violence and we need protection from it"

of gender, going against the 2014 NALSA (National Legal Services Authority) ruling, says queer and feminist activist Varsha.

The Act also goes against the Right to Freedom of Residence as it warrants that transgenders stay with their parents or approach a court. "For queer and transpersons, the natal family becomes a site of violence and we need protection from it. We need legal recognition for the chosen family," says Varsha, who works at Nazariya, a queer feminist resource group.

For Varsha, a political party's outlook towards violence in natal families and its ability to legalise a chosen family, besides its attitude towards legalisation of same-sex marriage, will influence her voting choice. ■

-Sonali Acharjee